



THE END OF BOSTON'S WEST END . . . HOMES DEMOLISHED, FAMILIES DISPLACED

The nerve!...trying to save a neighborhood

What is democracy coming to?
In Cambridge, Brattle Street
Brahmins huddle with black radicals
to protest the Kennedy library.

In Boston, irritating critics crawl
out of the woodwork to ask how
much money the developer of Park
Plaza is going to make. Or even
whether Park Plaza is just the gov-
ernor's way of telling the mayor
"thank you" for not opposing the
highway moratorium.

And people who should have
more respect suddenly decide to take
a swim in the healing, tax-free
waters of the Christian Science
Center's reflecting pool, just as if
they owned it.

It's getting so bad, a developer
can hardly demolish a neighborhood
without some nut complaining.

Things were different in the old
days. When Boston's leaders, in their
wisdom, decided that the sensible
thing to do with the old West End
was to throw out the poor people,
tear down their homes and put up
baby-pink towers for the rich, no-

ARCHITECTURE / By ROBERT CAMPBELL

body thought to complain. At least,
nobody who mattered.

But those days are over. Partly
through the efforts of sociologists
like Herbert Gans, who documented
the wrenching destruction of family
and social ties when the West End
"slum" was destroyed, both planners
and ordinary citizens are more
sophisticated today.

But they still don't talk to each
other because they don't trust each
other.

The planners and developers, by
and large, will go to any length to
avoid genuine citizen participation in
their efforts. They don't admit it, but
they see citizens as knee-jerk nay-
sayers, short-sighted, selfish and un-
trained in design, who will probably
delight in killing any development
proposal just for the pleasure of
watching it die.

And the citizens trust the plan-
ners even less. A recent survey
showed that half the people in Los

Angeles don't trust their own elected
officials to represent community in-
terests in decisions on highway loca-
tion.

In Boston, one suspects the dis-
trust ratio would be even higher.

Too many rigid, bureaucratic
plans over too many years have
come down on peaceful neighbor-
hoods like waffle irons. Like the
Duke of Argyll in the 18th century,
who grandly swept away an entire
village because he didn't like its
looks, our planners have planned for
people whom they didn't know, im-
posing abstractions that took little
account of the real, complex biology
of cities.

The same quality that makes it
possible for otherwise decent young
men to bomb Cambodia, enables in-
telligent planners to mindlessly run
a superhighway through a poor
neighborhood. In both cases the per-
petrator, out of touch with the
people whose lives he's affecting, falls

victim to abstractions. Abstractions
like "protective reaction." Or "re-
lieving congestion."

Patrick Geddes, the founder of
modern city planning, said it 50
years ago. Writing of the British
government's unfeeling attempts to
replan a city in India, Geddes wrote:

"One of the poor quarters of this
same town is at present threatened
with 'relief of congestion,' and we
are shown a rough plan in which the
usual gridiron of new thoroughfares
is hacked through its old-world vil-
lage life. We are told that this
sweeping and costly plan is not the
original one, but is regarded as a
moderate and even economical sub-
stitute for the first one of total dem-
olition . . ."

"We start walking through the
district, and find that the very first
house doomed to destruction is as
substantial, decent and even pleasing
as one could wish to see. Why then
should it be demolished? The answer
is straightening the new lane beside
it . . ."

How does such thoughtless plan-
ning happen? Geddes pointed out the
answer, equally applicable to our
own times. In the absence of person-
al contact with the neighborhood,
the planners' main interest, he said,
"is in the neat straight lines" of the
plan.

That kind of planning may be a
thing of the past, but the distrust it
engendered lives on.

People aren't willing any longer
to be the passive victims of plans
handed down from on high, or of
developers whose only concern is
profit.

As a result, perhaps the single
most important issue in architecture
and planning today is finding a way
to get ordinary citizens plugged into
the planning of new developments in
a way that's creative, and not merely
obstructionist.

Developers, increasingly, are
going to have to go, hat in hand, to
citizen review groups of all kinds.
And these groups, armed with envi-
ronmental impact laws and with po-
litical savvy and muscle, are going to
exact a price for their approval.

In some cases that price may be
petty harassment. In most, it's going
to be a better environment.